

Observations of birds made and recorded by “citizen scientists” in parks and gardens can provide ecologists with vital data on many species, such as the European Goldfinch.

In search of the monarch

Perhaps the most celebrated act of citizen science was one that set out to solve the mystery of where the migrating monarch butterfly went in winter. In 1952, a Canadian couple, zoologists Fred and Norah Urquhart, who had long been fascinated by the butterfly, set up a tagging scheme in an attempt to find where the insect ended its journey after setting out from southern Canada and the northern states of the US in fall. They enlisted the help of a small group of “citizen scientists” to help tag the wings of the butterflies and report sightings. From a dozen or so helpers, their Insect Migration Association, as it became known, grew to hundreds of volunteers who persisted for years, tagging hundreds of thousands of monarchs with the message “Send to Zoology, University of Toronto.”